



CHRIST PRESBYTERIAN CHURCH
NEW HAVEN

February 13, 2004

A Pastoral Letter:

Re. "The Passion of Christ" Movie

You have undoubtedly heard that Mel Gibson's "The Passion of Christ" will open in theaters nationwide on Wednesday, February 25th, 2004. As to be expected, the reviews range in both positive and negative extremes, even from within a so called "Christian point of view." Many evangelical and Catholic churches especially are seeing this, in the words of one promotional, as "the next great evangelism tool of our time." My desk has been flooded with all sorts of programmatic suggestions and tools in relation to this movie. As well, many of you have asked for my advice on the subject.

On a personal note, I confess that I have my reservations honestly. My primary reservation pertains to what Marshall McLuhan meant when he said that "the medium is the message." In other words, I am weary of the "big screen" as a medium to communicate properly the message of the gospel and especially an "image of Christ." By its very nature as an entertainment "medium" (in "Dolby" sound no less), it is oriented toward dramatization and sensationalism in a way that can obscure reality even while at the same time "seeming so real." Again, as a "medium," the "big screen" must necessarily "frame" that which is in truth a frameless reality. The effect of all this is to reduce a given message even if giving the impression of enhancing that message. And for every dramatic effect and decision in favor of one frame over another, there was necessarily an editorial decision that has less to do with "real reality" and more to do with someone's own "subjective reality." In short, I am particularly concerned that whatever image is properly conveyed in scripture by the medium of "word" will necessarily be obscured and revised by the medium of the "big screen." And again, the fact is that while being portrayed as (and I quote) an "authentic movie about Christ," it is in reality Mel Gibson's image of Christ, not to be confused with the Scripture's image as communicated in "word."

To illustrate my point perfectly, one person who viewed the film later stated, "It has been nearly three weeks since I saw the rough cut of The Passion. It is still impacting my life. I can't stop thinking about it. I have never seen a film that has so affected my life. It is powerful, moving, and disturbing. The film is true to the Bible and other historical evidence, yet it is alive with emotion and the harshness of reality. I do not want to see it again, yet I will be compelled from within to do so - not only again, but again and again. No one will be able to leave the theatre and not be moved at the core of their being."

Hmmm... As per my earlier concerns, this sort of reaction scares me. I for one am not sure that I want to expose myself, much less my children, to this kind of "power" as clearly

related to the medium's message concerning Christ as per Mel Gibson's interpretation. And yet, I notice that the impact is validated as being "true to the Bible and other historical evidence." Here again, a "framed" interpretation "seeming so real." And I wonder as well, after seeing it again and again in one's mind, if not literally in a theater, what really is being "seen" as to impact the most important relationship of my life!

Having said all this, my concern ought not to be confused with my great respect for the usefulness of "art" as directed by and for a Christian worldview. Art will necessarily involve a creative interpretation as for the sake of being properly provocative for the purpose of some good, as per our understanding of common grace/general revelation. And to be sure, many good people in our church and denomination will find it useful to view this movie, if only to participate in the cultural conversation that will be conjured up by it for the sake of Christian apologetics. Moreover, one could perhaps argue that the same respect for the power of big screen images that causes me pause, is from the reciprocal point of view, an argument in favor of its usefulness for the sake of getting ones attention. Therefore, I do see that it could possibly be useful as a potential pre-evangelistic tool by God, even in spite of the medium issues raised above.

Finally, I should also note that there is considerable debate about whether this movie is in violation of the 2nd commandment or not, as to forbid the making of images representing God. And to be sure, in so far as Christ is "God incarnate," our church refrains from using images of Christ in either our worship or Sunday school instruction for this reason. Now of course we all know that Christ was "in the image of man" even while also being the "exact representation of God." By his very incarnation Christ then had a corporal image. And yet, we know nothing of it except that it was most likely Palestinian. What we do know, however, is that by the medium of the word, no one sees an ethnic Christ, or even a particular image of Christ as to in any way become a barrier to our receiving him by way of a negative association. Rather, in knowing Christ abstractly through the medium of the word, he is able to represent all of humanity in his mediatorial role. The debated question then is whether or not the prohibition of the 2nd commandment necessarily excludes artistic license. Again, there is considerable debate about this even within our denomination. But for those who say that the 2nd commandment is not being violated, they are careful to say that the "image" being portrayed is not an image of "Christ" as much as it is an artist's impression of Christ for provocative reasons.

So then, you say, what do you recommend? Well, and to be sure, I would certainly take issue with showing this movie in the context of corporate worship-- not that any of you have suggested it. E.g. I would see this as a clear and blatant violation of the 2nd commandment and the diminishing of Christ's representation of all humanity IN THAT CONTEXT. It would also undermine the sufficiency of Scripture concerning it's unique way of "framing" our only rule of faith and practice, even as I believe preaching in "words" is the appropriate interpretive extension of the "Word." As to whether or not this movie is an appropriate art form as to not be harmful for personal faith and useful for the sake of Christian apologetics, I feel that I must leave this to the wisdom of each individual and family, notwithstanding the concerns I have raised already. I simply don't have a public "conviction" about this either way-- even if I have some obvious reservations.

And to be clear, if you do see the movie, I would say take special precaution to view it "critically" as you would any other movie or book authored by a mere mortal. In the spirit of 2Cor. 10:5, "We destroy arguments and every proud obstacle raised up against the knowledge

of God, and we take every thought captive to obey Christ." And by "critique" I don't mean against the standard "how authentic is it historically." Again, this would be to assume that which cannot be assumed relative to the medium of the big screen itself. Rather, you will want to critique the film against the standard "how authentic is it theologically" as per Mel Gibson's theological message as embedded within the medium. E.g. Is the portrayal of Christ's "passion" according to Mel Gibson what the Bible teaches concerning the theological *meaning* of Christ's passion and in Biblical proportions?

Beyond these personal thoughts, I would refer you to two reviews, both from a Christian and even "reformed" point of view, albeit taking very different positions on the subject. Perhaps these articles will assist you and your family in discerning what is most beneficial to your faith and practice on the issue, even as you recognize that your church takes no formal "stand" on the issue as it where regarding personal viewings of the movie. And as always, the gospel demands that we hold whatever point of view we have with a spirit of deference, humility and grace one to another (Rom. 14)!

Here are the reviews-- pro and con

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I am Yours in Christ,
Preston